of vermibed. It is useful as a foliar spray to enhance plant growth and yield. It is obtained from the burrows or **drilospheres** formed by earthworms. Nutrients, plant growth promoter substances and some useful microorganisms are present in vermiwash.

Earthworms can be used for recycling of waste food, leaf, litter and biomass to prepare a good fertilizer in container known as **wormery** or **wormbin**.

Earthworm Pests and Diseases

Earthworms are subjected to attack by a variety of pests. Most outbreaks are the result of poor bed management. Earthworm enemies include ants, springtails, centipedes, slugs, mites, certain beetle larvae, birds, rats, snakes, mice, toads, and other insects or animals which feed on worms. The earthworm has a number of internal parasites including numerous protozoa, some nematodes, and the larvae of certain flies. Larger predators can be excluded from worm beds by proper construction of the bins, and by use of screens or gratings at the bottom and top of the beds.

My vermicompost manufacturing unit is plagued by a number of red ants. Are there any bio-friendly measures to tackle the menace as I do not want to use any chemicals?

Advantages of Using Vermicompost

People are aware about benefits of organic inputs in farming. Vermicompost is excellent organic manure for sustainable agro-practices. So, marketing vermicompost is now a potential and flourishing industry. Retail marketing of vermicompost in urban areas is most promising. Vermicompost is neatly packed in designed and printed packets for sale. People of different age groups are involved in the production and selling of vermicompost. Marketing of vermicompost can provide a supplementary income.

i. Vermicompost is rich in essential plant nutrients.
ii. It improves soil structure texture, aeration, and water holding capacity and prevents soil erosion
iii. Vermicompost is a rich in nutrients and an eco-friendly amendment to soil for farming and terrace gardening.
iv. It enhances seed germination and ensures good plant growth

13.3 Sericulture

Silk is Nature's gift to mankind and a commercial fiber of animal origin other than wool. Being eco-friendly, biodegradable and self-sustaining material; silk has assumed special relevance in present age. Sericulture is an agro –based industry, the term which denotes commercial production of silk through silkworm rearing. Historical evidence reveals that sericulture was practiced in China long back and they preserved the secret for more than 3000 years and maintained monopoly in silk trade with the rest of the world. According to Western historians, mulberry cultivation spread to India about 140BC from China through Tibet. The fabulous silk from China and India were carried to European countries. The 7000 mile lengthy road, historically called the "**Silk road**" passing through Baghdad, Tashkent, Damascus and Istanbul was used for silk transport. Today more than 29 countries in the world are practicing sericulture and producing different kinds of silk. India stands second in silk production next to China.

Production of silk from the silk worm, by rearing practices on a commercial

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